

## The Kalewala.

BY JOHN OXENFORD.

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To a certain class of modern philologists, no poem in the world is more familiar than the Kalewala, the long epic, which is to the mythology and traditional lore of the Finns what the Iliad and Odyssey of Homer are to the heroic story of ancient Greece. It is the source from which nearly all the information connected with the religious creed, the moral notions, the customs, and the domestic details of a most remarkable race is to be obtained. If we would know how the Greeks of the heroic age prayed, fought, eat, drank, sported, and clothed themselves, we turn to the pages of Homer. If we would obtain similar knowledge on the subject of the Finns, we consult the Kalewala.

Though the traditions of the Finnish heroes are possibly as old as those of Achilles and Ajax, the arrangement of them into a continuous poem is a work of very recent date. No Wolfian controversy will arise respecting the construction of the Kalewala, for it is not more than twenty-five years since the Peisistratid who first put together the isolated songs, or Runes, published the result of his labours. Fragments of Finnish poetry, collected from the oral traditions of the people, had already made their appearance, though even the first important collection of these, which was made by Dr. Zacharias Topelius, dates no further back than 1822. An attempt made by Professor Becker, some ten years before, to arrange a few of the songs in consecutive order is just worth mentioning, because it probably suggested to Dr. Lönnrot the notion of making the same experiment on a larger scale. But it is with Dr. Lönnrot that the existence of the epic as an epic, with the title "Kalewala," begins. He published it in thirty-two Runes,—that is to say, books or cantos, for the word, which previously denoted an independent poem, now sinks into little more than a sign of division, though here and there, it must be confessed an abrupt transition occurs, to which a parallel would not be found in the Iliad or the Odyssey. In 1849 a second edition of the Kalewala was published, likewise under the superintendence of Dr. Lönnrot, containing fifty cantos and nearly 23,000 lines. It is this edition that philologists have in view when they quote from the Kalewala, unless they expressly refer to the earlier publication.

Although, as I have said, the Kalewala is familiar to a certain class of philologists, that class is scarcely a drop in that ocean of humanity, the British public. Hence, humbly relying on the assistance of the great Finnish scholars Castrén and Schiefner, I venture to narrate a curious cycle of legends that will be perfectly new to thousands, though the units may accuse me of telling an oft-told tale. In a word, I give the story of the Kalewala.